These breaks did not mean that Cuba became isolated. Rather, it developed an extremely activist foreign policy. Its military activities around the world placed it second only to the United States, and ahead of the USSR, the supposed second superpower.[23] Its civilian aid programs became the largest in the world, surpassing even international organizations like the United Nations or the World Health Organization. By 2006, Cuba had sent almost 400,000 soldiers and about 70,000 aid workers on missions abroad.[24] As Cuban-American political scientist Jorge Domínguez wrote in 1978, "Cuba is a small country, but it has a big country's foreign policy."[25]

Several different scholars, in the United States, in Cuba, and beyond, have found different ways to explain the size – and the nature – of Cuba's foreign policy. Jorge Domínguez argued that it was a form of realpolitik. As an isolated, small country, Cuba needed to create allies. Third World revolutionary movements were Cuba's natural partners; it was in Cuba's interest to help them succeed. Cuba's goal, as Domínguez's book's title suggests, was *To Make a World Safe for Revolution*.

Piero Gleijeses disagrees. Far from realpolitik, he argues, Cuba's foreign policies were motivated by revolutionary idealism. Cuba incurred huge risks with its activities in Africa. In directly challenging the United States in places like Angola, Cuba jeopardized relations not only with the United States but also with Western Europe and the Organization of American States. At certain points it even risked alienating the USSR. "Castro sent troops," Gleijeses concludes, "because he was committed to racial justice." "For no other country in modern times has idealism been such a key component of its foreign policy."[26]

Carlos Moore takes precisely the opposite view. Focusing on Cuba's involvement in Africa, he argues that foreign policy served to promote the illusion of commitment to black liberation, covering up the reality of racial inequality at home. It was a cynical, practically Machiavellian policy.[27]